

TRENDS IN TUNICS

The Bayeux Tapestry (actually an embroidery) documenting the Norman invasion of England in 1066 illustrates the fashion of the time: the tunic, shaped like a "T" with insertions for fullness. It was the basic clothing for Saxons and Normans, but the trend for wearing short tunics was relatively new – one of many continental fashions that King Edward the Confessor introduced when he came to the English throne in 1042 after exile at the Court of Normandy.

Most men wore two tunics: a linen undergarment covered by an over-tunic. The under-tunic was sometimes longer, so that the bottom of it peeped out below the hem of the over-tunic. Pulled on over the head, tunics had a slit at the front of the neck, bordered by a band or collar, often in a contrasting colour. A belt was worn, sitting at the waist or low on the hips, and could be used to tuck up extra length.

Although tunics were ubiquitous, the quality of the cloth reflected the wealth of the wearer. The aristocracy, often shown in the tapestry as pointing and giving orders, wore sumptuous silk tunics with gold embroidery imported from the East. The bright colours showed off expensive dyes. Much simpler, coarse-cloth tunics with close-fitting leggings were worn by labourers. The colours available to the ordinary people were shades of natural grey and brown, and greens and blues from plants.

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The English did Frenchify themselves...and make themselves ridiculous by their fantastic fashions...

WILLIAM OF MALMESBURY, 1095–1143

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◀ HISTORIC TUNICS

The Bayeux Tapestry, probably embroidered during the 1070s, provides a picture of the clothes worn by both nobles and serfs in the 11th century. Here, tunic-clad labourers build a fortified Norman base.

